RESIGNATION – THE OPPORTUNITY TO RECONSIDER

At the Quarterly Communication in March 2015, Grand Lodge amended Rule 183 to increase from 21 days to 60 the time allowed for a member to withdraw their resignation following a vote of the members of their Lodge to invite them to do so. The following extract from the Paper of Business for the December 2014 Quarterly Communication of Grand Lodge (when the Notice of Motion was proposed) explains the reasoning for this change, and offers guidance on how the Rule should operate:

RESIGNATIONS FROM PRIVATE LODGES UNDER RULE 183

- *Rule 183 sets out a clear procedure to be followed if a Brother wishes to resign from a Lodge (as opposed to resigning from the Craft).*

- *The first proviso to the Rule allows a Brother twenty-one days within which to withdraw his resignation if so desired by a majority of the members present when the resignation is communicated or notified to the Lodge at a regular meeting. It has been represented to the Board that the period of twenty-one days may, under modern conditions, be unduly restrictive. London and many Provinces now operate a system of "exit interviews" with the aim of ascertaining whether a resignation is owing to a general disillusionment with Freemasonry, or is related to the particular Lodge of which he is a member. In the latter case it is often possible for the Metropolitan or Provincial authorities to find a more convenient or congenial Lodge for the Brother to join so that his Masonic career is not interrupted. The Board considers that a period of sixty days would be more helpful in the process of retaining a Brother in the Craft and recommends that Rule 183 be amended accordingly. Notice of Motion appears at item 7 of the Paper of Business.*

- *The Board considers that it would be helpful if it gave guidance on the operation of the Rule and the measures that may be taken when a resignation is received.*

- *A Brother may resign orally in open Lodge, either with immediate effect or from a later date which he then specifies. Such resignation, once spoken, is irrevocable unless the Lodge votes immediately in accordance with the first proviso, that he be invited to withdraw it.*

- *The more usual method of resigning is by written notice to the Secretary, again either with immediate effect or from a later specified date. The Secretary is obliged to report the resignation to the Lodge at the next regular meeting, unless the Brother has withdrawn it in the meantime, and once communicated to the Lodge it becomes irrevocable (unless the Lodge votes to invite him to withdraw it). The resignation takes effect from the date the Secretary received it, or from such later date as may have been specified in the notice. The Rule requires the written notice to be given to the Secretary and the resignation can be withdrawn by a further written notice at any time before it is reported to the Lodge, but once reported is irrevocable (unless the Lodge votes to invite the Brother to withdraw it).*

- *In June 2009 the Grand Lodge accepted the Board's recommendation that a resignation may in the first instance be communicated by e-mail, but that it should only become effective if before the next regular meeting of the Lodge the Secretary receives a written confirmation*

bearing an original signature of the member; it then takes effect (in accordance with its terms) from the moment the Secretary received the e-mail message.

- *It is suggested that on receipt of a letter of resignation a Secretary should contact the Almoner of the Lodge (who should already be monitoring regular absentees from Lodge meetings) without delay, so that he may ascertain the reason for the resignation. He should normally at the same time inform the Metropolitan or Provincial Office that the Brother has resigned. The Secretary, in writing to the Brother himself, should take care to do no more than acknowledge receipt of the resignation and state that it will be reported to the Lodge at the next meeting; in particular he should not purport to accept the resignation on behalf of the Lodge (which he has no power to do).*

- *It is entirely for a Lodge to decide whether to afford a Brother the opportunity to reconsider his resignation, but it is suggested that, except in cases where the procedure would obviously be inappropriate, no harm would be done by giving him that opportunity.*